



Family time: Leander Paes with his daughter and parents. "I am here because of all the love and support I got from so many people," said Leander, struggling to hold back tears in a hall crammed with his well-wishers. PICTURE COURTESY: ITHF

after the retirement of Tom Brady, the NFL's greatest quarterback.

He's surprised to learn that Indians play tennis, let alone that two of them have made it into the International Tennis Hall of Fame, right there in the Casino Theatre. But as you pull up to the nearly century-old brownstone Viking Hotel in Newport's Historic Hill neighbourhood, it's easy to mistake the scene for a big, exuberant Indian wedding. The lobby is awash with colour and chaos as men and women embrace like long-lost friends, even as bemused hotel staff and locals do their best to navigate around the lively spectacle.

A short walk, quicker than the ancient-looking trolley cars trundling along the street, past columned manors and mansions, brings you to the Hall of Fame Museum. Here, you find even more Indians buzzing with impatient energy, all awaiting the arrival of soon-to-be inductees

Leander Paes and Vijay Amritraj.

Among Leander's memorabilia, now on display in this quaint, rich oceanfront town, is his most cherished possession: his 1996 Atlanta Olympics bronze medal.

"The main reason I started playing sports was to emulate my dad, who won an Olympic [hockey bronze in Munich 1972] medal. My parents were there [in Atlanta], and they mean the world to me. Both of my siblings gave up a lot for me. I am here because of all the love and support I got from so many people," said Leander, struggling to hold back tears in a hall crammed with his well-wishers.

Leander's victory in Atlanta, defeating Brazilian Fernando Meligeni for the bronze, propelled him into Indian sports folklore. In a country starved for Olympic success, he became a new hero. And his triumph inspired a generation of Indian athletes to believe they could compete with the best. Since that historic medal, India has never come back from the Olympics empty-handed, a stark contrast to the previous routine disappointments.

Leander always wore his heart on his sleeve on the tennis court; his emotion and courage were as much

part of his game as were his lightning-quick reflexes at the net. His passion was even more intense when he played for India, be it at the Davis Cup, Olympics or the Asian Games. That same emotion was evident as he spoke about Martina Navratilova, with whom he won two mixed doubles Grand Slams. Navratilova and Leander's 2003 Wimbledon trophy is also on display. Calling the 59-time Grand Slam winner his 'North Star', Leander said: "She has been my guiding light and has inspired me through longevity of lifestyle—diet, sleep, training methods, recovery. I got a chance to play with her in 2003, and we won the Australian Open and Wimbledon. Playing with her was special, as I grew up watching her play on black-and-white television in Kolkata. And then getting to know her as a person and winning Wimbledon together is special. She is not just a champion of tennis, but she is a champion of life."

For Amritraj, inducted in the contributor category, sport has always been a way to unify the world. "My parents were flying blind when we got into this sport we call tennis. Never knew where it was going to take us. I've often said that my greatest talent was being born to the